Resounding the Salvadoran Civil War Digital Music Archive

Méndez, Talia
tmendezm@uwo.ca
Western University, Canada

Abrams Ansari, Emily
emily.ansari@uwo.ca
Western University, Canada

This paper presents an ongoing research-creation project: a digital anarchive of folk songs from the El Salvador civil war. This collection gathers recordings and other data that narrate El Salvador's civil war (1980-92), particularly from the perspective of the subsistence farmers who led the uprising against their autocratic government. It incorporates historic recordings made during the war, especially in the Honduran refugee camps to which many Salvadorans fled, modern field recordings of remembered wartime songs, and recordings of songs written more recently by survivors and young musicians who did not directly experience the war. We argue that this resource will enable an exploration of music as a cultural expression of wartime experiences, particularly from a present-future perspective. By experimenting with anarchiving practices and digital archiving methods we consider how the archive can also serve as an alternative form of justice in the postwar context, addressing the unfulfilled recommendations of the 1993 UN Commission on the Truth for El Salvador. This approach is enacted through fieldwork, historical memory workshops, and prototyping conducted in the community of Las Vueltas, El Salvador, and at the Mediateca at the Centro Arte para la Paz arts centre in Suchitoto.

This digital song anarchive is one outcome of the Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council (SSHRC)-funded project, Surviving Memory in Postwar El Salvador. The larger project is an international partnership of survivors, scholars, architects, artists, lawyers, museums, community organizers, local leaders, civil society organizations, and mental health professionals who are committed to documenting the history of the Salvadoran Civil

War (1980-1992) and preventing future violence. In creating an archive of songs from the war, we seek to promote its educational and creative use by safeguarding, preserving, and disseminating its contents. Since 2017, the team has collaborated with survivor groups to pursue three key activities: (1) collecting historic materials such as song recordings and lyrics; (2) recording present-day commemoration events and their soundscapes, facilitating historical memory workshops about music-making during the war, and eliciting contemporary performances of wartime music for recording; and (3) conducting community-based workshops to design the anarchive collaboratively.

Considering the relationship that Salvadoran communities have with wartime music in its specific historical memory context, anarchival practices can help interrogate—and ultimately challenge—the colonial logic of archives by questioning what should be archived (Stoler). Springgay states, “The anarchive is less a thing than a process or an action” (2022, p. 114). Rather than emphasizing what is archived, the anarchive prioritizes the process of engaging with archival content.

For our team, this process entails two specific priorities. First, beyond merely gathering content, we want to honor the Salvadoran context by thinking "through the ties between consciousness, labor, cultural production, and freedom seeking"(Mckittrick, 61). Our focus is on how Salvadorans will engage with the archive—what questions will arise from the present and future material, how they will understand the content, and the possible categories for organizing and accessing it that they will envisage. Informed by their lived experiences, these categories can guide us in establishing meaningful community conversations and, at the same time, debates regarding digital methods. While we might approach the archive with a researcher’s logic, their historical and cultural perspectives may lead to different categorizations.

Although Participatory Action Research is fundamental to many of the historical memory methodologies employed by the research team, we go beyond it with the digital song anarchive to embrace 'anarchiving as research-creation,' neither seeking to resolve problems nor find definitive solutions, as is typical in qualitative or quantitative research. Instead, this approach seeks to through creative processes that problematize cultural phenomena (Leavy; Loveless). In this sense, our objective in building the archive collaboratively is to raise questions and foster deeper understanding of the socio-political context to stimulate reflection and generate something new, rather than only to represent or inform.

For Springgay (2022), ‘anarchiving as research-creation’ is a theoretical framework that understands anarchiving as indeterminate, as felt , and as response-ability (p. 19). Springgay’s work embraces Charles Merewheter's proposal to turn “excavation sites into construction sites” (2006, p. 146), arguing that archive practices should be dynamic and participatory. Instead of merely uncovering and preserving the past (“excavation”), archives should be spaces where people “construct” knowledge by actively engaging with, interpreting, and building upon the archival material (Ernst, 2018; Neiger et al., 2011). This way, the archive is put in a vulnerable position where users are encouraged to interact with the history. This approach emphasizes the importance of action, expression, and interaction in the creation of knowledge and how these forms of inquiry can open new avenues for understanding the world in an ethical and affective way.

This kind of methodological experimentation, applied to the process of gathering archival materials, creating categories collaboratively, and determining design decisions in conversation, allows us to evaluate the ordinary processes of designing a digital song anarchive and reflect on

questions such as: How can affective, relational, and performative engagement reshape our understanding of archival interaction? How do anarchival dimensions such as indeterminacy and response-ability integrate into co-design practices? What methodological tensions emerge from building a hybrid model that blends structured archival systems with speculative, community-responsive design? And what does it mean to design not for closure, but for transformation and community technological autonomy and ownership?

As we seek answers to these questions through our research, we gain a deeper understanding of how the 'anarchiving as research-creation' approach adds vitality to the creation of a digital song anarchive, transforming it into a collaborative exploratory platform. We seek an anarchive that resists static representation and instead invites reactivation and relational engagement. Our current plan is to create a hybrid prototype built using two platforms: Glide (or a similar no-code, mobile-first tool for intuitive and relational access), and Omeka, a stable infrastructure for metadata and preservation. While we are still assessing Glide's suitability, we recently shared a low-fidelity prototype and another one with Glide in a workshop in Suchitoto and Santa Martha, El Salvador, with musicians and community members. We are committed to an ethical position that prioritizes community autonomy. The archive must adapt to ethical practices, not the other way around. The tools used must support this value without reverting to static, institution-driven structures. Initial categorization of the songs used archival metadata and thematic analysis to form ten categories (e.g., war context, character, return, solidarity). These were intentionally unsettled through field workshops, where participants revised, expanded, or dissolved categories through performance and dialogue. Subsequent relational checkpoints with musicians and scholars enabled us to reflect critically on questions of authorship, re-

gional memory, and representation.

This work treats the Digital Song Anarchive not as an endpoint but a platform for collective inquiry. Drawing on the principles of design justice (Costanza-Chock, 2020), we reimagine the role of digital humanities practitioners as facilitators of shared authorship. The archive is co-constructed with Salvadorans, not imposed. Technologies are selected for their accessibility, sustainability, and usability by non-expert Salvadoran stewards of the archive. Rather than aiming for completeness or objectivity, we center ambiguity, multiplicity, and embodied interpretation. Songs are understood not as fixed objects but as evolving nodes in a network of memory. This is a tradition that often mixed genres, re-used melodies with new lyrics, and layered meanings—choices that make it even more critical that an anarchive designed to document them serves as a living and speculative infrastructure.

Archives of this type can be active agents in revitalizing historical memory and have the potential to generate new forms of representation, reinterpretation, and reconstruction. This interdisciplinary approach expands the boundaries of the concept of digital archiving, not only delving into questions of methodology, ethics, and inclusivity but also navigating a careful balance between tradition and innovation. By putting anarchiving practices into conversation with their apparent opposite, traditional digital archiving methods, we aim to create conditions that empower community agency, working together with our archives' contributors and users to create a more equitable and inclusive resource that truly reflects the diversity of wartime experiences. This approach also centres our community partners to reflect their contribution to the digital song anarchive, ensuring that the community is central to the decision-making

process and is happy to take ownership of the collection, both during the building of the archive and long after its launch.

This project thus not only provides a tangible application of anarchiving as research-creation ; it also presents a critical challenge to the colonial underpinnings of traditional archives. It bridges theory and practice, offering a participatory and inclusive model of archiving. By showcasing this music archive's collaborative process, we highlight the potential of this approach to community archive projects to offer an alternative form of justice that responds to the emotional and cultural needs of Salvadoran communities.

This interdisciplinary work aligns with the conference's emphasis on diversity by challenging hegemonic archival logics and presenting a methodological framework that is both reflexive and innovative. By focusing on music—a powerful yet ephemeral form of cultural memory—this project illustrates how digital humanities initiatives can be ethically and collaboratively designed to amplify marginalized voices and histories.